

That would make the Samastipur-born the youngest player to debut for India, surpassing Sachin Tendulkar, who earned his first cap at 16.

However, Pakistan's Hasan Raza, who debuted at 14 years and 233 days in 1996, would still remain the youngest to have made an international appearance.

Whether it is too soon for Sooryavanshi to wear the hallowed Blues can be a debate for another day. What is undeniable is that behind the baby face lies a rare mix of audacity and assurance, perhaps even the outline of India's next big story.

One call away

The transformation, in many ways, has been as rapid as it has been remarkable. Let's rewind to January 2024. Zubin Bharucha, director of

Stamping authority: Led by the then 14-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's century, India secured a sixth Under-19 World Cup title in Harare earlier this year. ^{AP}

High Performance at RR, received a call from Samar Qadri, a former Bihar cricketer and a scout associated with the IPL franchise.

Qadri spoke enthusiastically about a young player who had begun attracting attention immediately after making his First-Class debut.

Although Qadri believed the kid warranted serious consideration, Bharucha approached the matter with measured restraint.

"Everyone wanted to know who this 12-year-old making his Ranji debut was, and that's when Samar told me about his talent. My thinking was clear: let's see him bat live and put him under pressure at the trials," Bharucha tells *Sportstar*.

Interest from other franchises soon followed, but RR maintained a particularly close watch, thanks to Qadri's timely updates. As Sooryavanshi continued to perform for India U-19, internal discussions gathered momentum, eventually culminating in a message from talent identification coordinator Akshay Karanje: "There's an amazing young player who deserves a look in..."

That one text set things in motion.

The Boy Wonder

Sooryavanshi was invited to the Royals' academy in Talegaon for trials, where Bharucha had his first close look.

Curiosity prompted a simple question: who is your favourite cricketer? Bharucha expected an answer like Rishabh Pant, given their similarity in approach.

But Sooryavanshi's response surprised him.

"Brian Lara," he said.

The reply was unexpected, not just because of the generational gap, but because it hinted at a deeper engagement with the game. Sooryavanshi had gone back, watched Lara's batting, studied it, and internalised aspects of it.

As the trials progressed, those influences began to surface.

"There is an almost Laraesque aspect in his game," Bharucha says. "He has got a lovely backlift that goes over his head and comes through. It's very rare. The bat actually crosses the vertical, almost goes in front of his hands and wrists. It's unbelievable."

Even then, Bharucha chose not to rush to a conclusion. He preferred evidence under pressure.

When Sooryavanshi faced a left-arm quick during the trials, Bharucha anticipated a difficult start.

Instead, he witnessed a moment that shifted his perspective. A delivery expected to beat the outside edge was dispatched over extra cover for six.

A glitch in the matrix, Bharucha

